

Week 10: Early Trade and Exchange

JSS1 Nigerian History — First Term Lesson Note (Deep-Dive Edition)

Introduction

Long before modern currency and international shipping, Nigerian societies engaged in extensive trade, both locally and across vast distances. This week examines local trade, the trans-Saharan trade, and the routes that connected Nigerian societies to the wider world.

Local Trade

Within and between Nigerian communities, trade was commonly conducted through **barter** (exchanging goods directly) at local markets, alongside the use of early forms of currency such as **cowrie shells**. Farmers, craftsmen, and traders exchanged food crops, tools, pottery, cloth, and other goods, often at scheduled market days that rotated between neighbouring towns.

Trans-Saharan Trade

The **trans-Saharan trade** connected West African societies, including those in what is now northern Nigeria, to North Africa and the Mediterranean world across the Sahara Desert, using organized **camel caravans**.

Goods Traded	Direction
Gold, kola nuts, leather goods, enslaved people	Exported northward from West Africa
Salt, cloth, horses, books, and manufactured goods	Brought southward into West Africa

Cities such as **Kano** and **Katsina** grew into major trading hubs because of their position along these trade routes, becoming centres of wealth, Islamic scholarship, and craft production.

Trade Routes

Trade routes linked northern Nigerian cities to trading centres across the Sahara, such as Timbuktu, Ghadames, and cities in North Africa like Tripoli. Control of these routes brought great wealth and influence to empires such as **Kanem-Bornu**, which was positioned to benefit from taxing and protecting trade passing through its territory.

Real-Life Application

The historic trading role of cities like Kano continues today, as Kano remains one of Nigeria's major commercial centres. Local markets, still central to Nigerian daily life, carry forward the tradition of community trade described in this topic, even though barter has largely given way to modern currency.

Vocabulary

Word	Meaning
Barter	The direct exchange of goods or services without using money

Caravan	A group of traders travelling together, often with camels, across long distances
Trade route	An established path used regularly for transporting goods between regions

Evaluation Questions

- 1 What is barter, and how was it used in local Nigerian trade?
- 2 Name one early form of currency used in local Nigerian trade.
- 3 What was the trans-Saharan trade, and which desert did it cross?
- 4 Name two goods exported northward from West Africa in the trans-Saharan trade.
- 5 Name two goods brought southward into West Africa through this trade.
- 6 Why did cities like Kano and Katsina grow into major trading hubs?
- 7 How did control of trade routes benefit an empire like Kanem-Bornu?
- 8 What method of transport was mainly used to cross the Sahara for trade?
- 9 Compare local trade and trans-Saharan trade — what is one key difference?
- 10 In your own words, explain why trade was important for the growth of early Nigerian societies.

(Weeks 11–13 are Revision, Examination, and Closing — no new content in these weeks.)